

ESTHER

THE BOOK OF ESTHER.

PREFACE.

This Book takes its name from queen Esther; whose history is here recorded.

The general opinion of almost all commentators on the Holy Scripture, make Mardochai the writer of it: which also may be collected below from C. ix. 20.

Ch. --- He and the queen were certainly authors of the letter, (H.) enjoining the celebration of the feast of Purim, or "lots," which is the ground-work (C.) of the present narration. D. --- The compiler has also had recourse to the archives of the kingdom of Persia: so that his work has all the authority that can be required of a profane historian; and being moreover inspired in all its parts, we cannot refuse to receive it with the utmost respect. Those additions which are not now in Hebrew, (C.) though they were perhaps formerly, (W. Origen. D.) have been carefully preserved by S. Jerom, and were recognized by the ancient Vulg. as they are at present by the Greek, without any distinction.

Lysimachus, the Greek translator, was probably the author of them. C. xi. 1. C.

--- The objections of Capellus against this "Greek scribbler," as he is pleased to style him, despising the judgment of both Jews and Christians, are in general very unaccountably borrowed (H.) from the Latin version, and are easily refuted. Houbigant. --- Those Jews, who have rejected this work entirely, with Melito, (Eus. Hist. iv. 26. S. Greg. Naz. &c.) ought not to prevail against the consent of the majority, (C.) expressed in the Councils of Laodicea, Carthage, Trent, sess. 4, &c. To read this book according to the order of time, we should begin C. xi. v. 2, &c. C. i. ii. and xii. and iii. to v. 14; then we find the distress of the Jews in the rest of that chapter, and in C. xiii. to v. 8, and their delivery in C.

iv.

to ix. v. 17, and C. xiii. v. 8, &c. and C. xiv. xv. and xvi. The consequences of these events are recorded C. ix. v. 17, &c. to C. xi. 1. (W.) with which verse the book ends, in the Greek editions.

H. --- They vary considerably, as did the copies of the ancient Vulgate, which called forth the complaints of S. Jerom, Pref. But the Church has distinguished what was spurious from the genuine word of God; so that the doubts of Lyran, Sixtus, (Bib. viii.) &c. respecting the fragments at the end of the book being not canonical, ought no longer to be indulged; much less can the boldness of many Lutherans, (C.) and particularly of Le Clerc, (Houbigant) be tolerated, who represent the whole work as a mere fiction. The Jews have a greater respect for it than for any of the prophets; whose works, they say, will perish at the coming of the Messiah: whereas this will subsist with the books of Moses, and the feast of Purim will never be abolished. C. ix. 28.

Maimon. --- Ben. Gorion (ii. 2.) admits the additions. But Josephus is silent about them, as he probably did not find them in his copy. C. --- He recites, however, both the epistles of Assuerus.

Ant. xi. 6. D. --- It is not agreed whether these events happened before or after the captivity. But it is now most commonly supposed, that Esther was married to Darius Hystaspes, A. 3489, about the time of the dedication of the temple. C.

xiv. 9. He had been on the throne six years, and reigned other thirty. See Herod. vii. 4. C. --- Josephus thinks that Esther was the queen of Artaxerxes Longimanus, who was a great friend of the Jews. D. --- The Thalmud attributes this work to the great Synagogue, consisting of Esdras, Mardochai, Joachim,

&c. and, as various persons might write the same history, the Greek, with the additions, seems to be taken from one copy, and the Hebrew from another rather more concise, (Huet. D.) but equally inspired. H.

ESTHER 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. In. Heb. "and in." In this manner the books of Scripture are usually connected. Sept.

place first the dream of Mardochai. C. xi. 2. C. --- Assuerus. Sept. Artaxerxes; as C. xvi. 1.

The former is the title of Median, the latter of the Persian, monarchs. This king reigned over both nations, and was most probably Darius Hystaspes, the third king of the Persians, (T.) who subdued India, &c. Herod. C. T. --- Some understand Cambyzes, (1 Esd. iv. Genebrard) or Xerxes (Scalig.) or Artaxerxes Longimanus, (Bellarm. Salien) or Memnon, (Euseb.) or Ochus.

Serarius. --- But (C.) the author of 3 Esd. iii. 1. and iv. 43. seems clearly declared for Hystaspes.

T. --- Though that work be not canonical, (D.) it may claim some authority, as an ancient history.

H. --- This king gave orders for the building of the temple. 1 Esd. vi. 1. 14. ---

India. Part had been (C.) subject to Xerxes. Herod. iv. 44. --- Ethiopia, beyond Egypt, paid an acknowledgment.

Cambyzes had taken possession of this country. C. --- Some understand a part of Arabia to be meant. D. --- Seven: 120 had been regulated by Darius, the Mede. Dan. vi. 1. H. --- The number might vary as the monarch chose. D. ---

Herodotus (iii. 89.) only specifies "twenty." But he speaks of large departments, to which he intimates that several others were subordinate. C. ---

Provinces. Heb. medina, "seat of judges." H. --- Prefecture. M.

Ver. 2. Captial. Heb. "palace, (Prot. H.) or castle," (C.) may also signify "a capital." Mont. &c.

--- Hystaspes founded this ancient royal city of Persia, (Pliny vi. 27.) or he greatly embellished it.

C. Ælian, Anim. xiii. 18. T. --- He seems to have resided here almost constantly.

The preceding kings (C.) spent the winter in this warm climate, and perhaps the spring. See 2 Esd. i. 1. They spent other parts of the year at Ecbatana and at Babylon. C.

Ver. 3. Reign. When he was solemnly crowned, again, (T.) or removed his court, (C.) and dedicated this new capital, with feasting, &c. H.

Ver. 4. Days, or a full half year, according to their reckoning. Nabuchodonosor, after his victory over Arphaxad, (Judith i.) feasted 120 days; Dionysius of Syrachuse, 90; (Aristot.) Solomon seven; (3 K. viii. 63.) and David three; when he was recognized by all Israel. 1 Par. xii. 39. The Gaul, Ariamnes, gave a fest to all his countrymen for a whole year. Athen. iv. 13. --- The Roman emperors sometimes treated all the citizens of Rome, and Alexander did the like to 9000

of his chief officers for one day. But the magnificence of Assuerus surpasses all the rest. The Persians were famous on this account. --- Persicos odi, puer, apparatus. Hor. i. Ode 38. C.

Ver. 5. Expired, (Feuardent) or in the last week. M. C. --- King. The Persian monarchs delighted in agriculture. Cyrus the younger, planted trees at Sardis, and never ate till he had taken some exercise of this or of a military nature.

Xenoph. Memor. Cicero Senect.

Ver. 6. Were. Prot. " where were, " white, green, and blue hangings. --- Ivory.

Heb. "silver." H.

--- Beds, to lie down on at table; though sitting was formerly the fashion. Gen.

xliii. 33. The other custom prevailed among the more luxurious nations, and was observed in our Saviour's time, each person reclining upon his left arm, and having his feet behind the next. T. --- These beds were made very low, in Persia; so that Alexander had one put under his feet, when he sat on the throne of Darius, as he was not so tall. Curt. v. 7. --- Their magnificence was surprising.

Herod. ix. 81. C. --- Variety, in Mosaic work. T. --- They lay upon sheep skins.

Chal. Sept. "and the beds (or coverlets) were transparent, with various flowers, and full-blown roses, all round."

H.

Ver. 7. Vessels. When Lysanias had taken the camp of Mardonius, and beheld the rich vessels, he could not help expressing a surprise that people possessing such advantages, should come to molest the Lacedemonians, who lived so poorly. Herod. ix. 79.

Ver. 8. Neither. Heb. "and the drinking was according to the law." Gr. "was not according to the pre-established law;" (H.) as the usual custom was altered, on this occasion; and thus both may be accurate. The Persians had commonly a king of the feast, whose orders all were obliged to obey in drinking. Hor. i. Ode 4. Eccli. xxxii. 1. --- This was an occasion of quarrels, (S. Jer.) and of intoxication. Agesilaus followed the example of Assuerus. Darius, and Cyrus the younger, gloried in being able to drink much wine without being deranged.

C.

Reges dicuntur urgere culullis,

Et torquere mero, quem perspexisse laborant,

An sit amicitia dignus. Hor. ad Pison.

Among friends, these "absurd laws" wer laid aside.

Siccat inequales calices conviva, solutus

Legibus insanis. Hor. ii. Sat. 6. C.

This may suggest to Christians, that they ought not to urge any to get drunk, (S. Aug. ser. 231. de Temp.) lest they should be condemned by the very heathens. W. --- Would, and thus prevent disorders as much as possible.

Athen. x. 6.

Ver. 9. Vasthi. Sept. Astin. H. --- Serarius suspects she was the king's sister, or daughter, as such marriages were common in Persia. T. --- The name is not very different from that of Atossa, the daughter of Cyrus, who was married to Cambyses, Smerdis, and Darius; to the latter of whom she bore four children.

Herod. iii. 68. and vii. 3. --- This prince had other wives, particularly Artistona, (C. our Hadossa, (H.) or Esther) whom he espoused a virgin, and love the most.

Herodotus seems to confound her with Atossa. --- Dwell. Some Greek copies have "in her own palaces." Usher. --- It was proper for women to be more retired. M. --- The men feasted in the open air. H.

Ver. 10. Wine. From the king's excess, and the haughtiness of Vasthi, God took occasion to advance Esther, and to deliver his people. C. --- Mauman. Sept.

"Aman." T. --- But the names vary. The Persians seem to have had a predilection for the number seven, v. 14. C. Gr. "the seven eunuchs, ministers (deacons) of Artaxerxes."

Ver. 11. Head. But without any other covering. Chal. Sulpitius entertained perhaps the same idea. Stulto rege consultior, pudens, virorum oculis spectaculum corporis præbere jussa, abnuit.

H. --- Some Greek copies assert, very improbably, (C.) that she was sent for "to be crowned queen." --- Beautiful. "The Persian ladies were noted for beauty,"

(Ammian) insomuch that Alexander called them eye-sores, oculorum dolores.

Curt. --- Only prostitutes appeared publicly at feasts. Macro. vii. 1. S. Amb. de Elia. i. 15. --- In effect, Vasthi's refusal conformable to the laws of the country.

Josephus. Plut. in Themist. --- Her offence consisted, therefore, rather in her haughty carriage or words. H. --- For the proposal was neither decent nor safe for the king, (Grot.) as the history of Candaules shews. Herod. i. Not. Var. in Sulp.

Ver. 12. Fury. This is the usual consequences of excess. W.

Ver. 13. According. Heb. "knew the times, (for so was the king's custom with those who knew law and judgment.) And the next," &c. H. --- These were the magi, more particularly versed in the constitutions of the country. The Persians commonly held their consultations over wine.

Herod. i. 133. --- Sept. "and the king said to his friends, Thus has Astin spoken; do therefore, in this affair, law and judgment. Then came forth to him Arkesaios and Saresthaïos, and Malesear, the princes of the Persians and Medes, men near the king, and who sat first after the king. H. ---

The old Vulg. places Mardocheus first. These seven counsellors were perhaps styled the king's relations," (Brisson i. p. 171.) and administered justice; as even the kings referred their causes to them. Plut. Artax. &c.

Ver. 16. Mamuchan. Old Vulg. "Mardocheus." Yet the Jews say this was the infamous Aman; and one Greek copy has Bilgaïos, (C.) and Arabo,

"Mouchaios." C. iii. 1. and xii. 6. He was the youngest, but spoke first, as was sometimes the case.

Ver. 18. Wives. Gr. τυράννιδες, "princesses, or female tyrants." --- Slight. Sept.

**"dare to slight their husbands. Wherefore if," &c. H. --- Just. Heb.
"enough of contempt and indignation."**

**This may be referred either to the king or to the women's husbands.
The example will prove a source of continual quarrels. C. --- Brentius
approves the decision of this parasite; though S.**

**Amb. &c. think that the queen was justified by the laws, which the king
had no right to infringe, to gratify his drunken humour, v. 10. Luther
would also wrest this text in favour of adultery, p.ii.**

Devort. p. 177. W.

Ver. 19. Altered. This regarded the more solemn acts, signed by the counsellors. Dan. vi. 17.

Grotius. --- Some decrees were neglected or changed. C. viii. 9. 1 Esd. iv. 5. 21.

and vi. 1. C.

Ver. 21. Counsel. It was very inconclusive; (M.) and even supposing the queen were guilty of some indiscretion, the punishment was too severe. M. Grotius, v.

11. H.

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CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Suffered. He began to repent. The Persians used to deliberate when warm with wine: but their decrees were not ratified till they had examined them again the next day. Herod. i. 133. ---

This was not the case here; the king divorced his wife without any delay. C. ---

Sept. intimate that he presently lost thoughts of her. "He no longer remembered Vasthi with any affection, reflecting what she had said, and how he had condemned her." H. --- But the Alex. copy agrees with the Heb. C.

Ver. 2. Beautiful. Thus Abisag was brought to David. 3 K. i. 2. The Turkish emperors select women from all their dominion, without distinction of noble or ignoble; as all are their slaves.

Ver. 3. House. Distinct from the palace, v. 14. --- Women's. Heb. "things for rubbing, (C.) or purification;" (H.) such as perfumes, but not clothes.

Ver. 4. Commanded. Heb. "did so."

Ver. 5. Jew. He was of the tribe of Benjamin. But all went by this name, after the captivity.

Mardochai had probably returned from Jerusalem, seeing things were unfinished there. 1 Esd. ii.

2. C. --- Semei, who cursed David. Chal. --- Cis. The head of the royal family of Saul; whence authors have concluded that he and Esther were of royal blood, (C.) and descendants of Miphiboseth. T.

Ver. 6. Who. This may refer to Cis, the great-grandfather of Mardochai, if we postpone this history till the latter end of the Persian

monarchy. D. --- But it more naturally applies to Mardochai himself, who (C. xi. 4. T.) was led captive 80 years before, being then perhaps 10

years old, so that he would now be only 90; an age when many are fit for great things. C. Cic. de Senect. --- He might even have been an infant when taken, and of course would not be much above 80 when he came into such favour. H.

Ver. 7. Brothers. Josephus, (xi. 6.) the old Latin version of the Syr. Abenezra,

&c. suppose that Mardochai was uncle to Esther. But the Heb. Syr. Gr. and Chal. assert that he was only her cousin. Sept. "daughter of Aminadab, (or rather Abihail, v. 15.) his father's brother, and her name was Esther; and after her parents were dead, he educated her for a wife;" eis gunaika, as some Rabbins also maintain, believing she was an heiress. Yet other Greek copies, Heb. &c. read, "he educated her as a daughter, thugatera: for the damsel was very beautiful." He had probably adopted her. C. --- Edissa. Heb. hadassa, (H.) or hadassah, signified "of myrtle." M. --- Esther,

"a sheep." C.

Ver. 9. And he, Egeus, commanded the under eunuch. T. --- Heb. "he quickly gave her her things for purifications, (v. 3.) and her portions, with seven maids, suitable for her, out of the king's house; and he charged her and her maids to dwell in the best of the women's house," (H.) where things were the most commodious. C.

Ver. 10. Would. Heb. "had not declared." He was not influenced to treat her thus on account of her royal extraction. H. --- In effect, the Jews were despised. C.

Ver. 11. Court. He was one of the life-guards. C. xi. 3. T. --- This situation enabled him to disclose a conspiracy, (v. 23. and C. xii. 5.) as he often went to enquire after the health of Esther.

C.

Ver. 12. Turn. This was rigidly observed, in that country, where polygamy prevailed. Gen. xxx.

16. Herod. iii. 69. --- The wives were "shut up in separate apartments," (Just. i.

9.) in the remotest parts of the palace. C. --- Twelfth. A full year elapsed before they could be admitted. --- A sweet.

Prot. " other things for the purifying of the women." H. --- It would be difficult to form an adequate idea of the luxury of the Persians, if the Scripture had not informed us. The kings were not satisfied with one wife. Assuerus had 400; (Josephus) and Darius Codomannus carried 360

with him, in his expeditions. Curt. iii. --- Parmenio took an incredible number of his concubines, at Damascus. Athen. xiii. 9. --- They were not all treated alike, but all were very sumptuously adorned. Cities were allotted to furnish one with sandals, another with girdles, &c. Cic. in Verrem. v. C.

Ver. 15. Abihail. Sept. "Aminadab, brother of Mardochai's father." H. v. 7.

Ver. 16. Tenth. Sept. and old Vulg. "twelfth month, which is Adar." Tebeth corresponds with December and January. C. --- Notwithstanding all exertions, Esther had been near four years in preparing; (T. C. i. 3. C.) unless some years had elapsed before she was brought, v. 12. H. ---

She was guilty of no sin in becoming an inferior wife of the king. M. T.

Ver. 17. Crown. Lit. "diadem," (H.) which was a bandage "of purple, striped with white," by which the queen was distinguished from the

other wives. C. --- The king wore "a four-square cidaris," with a similar ornament. Alex. Genial. i. 27.

--- Only one queen was chosen from all the wives, and she was "adored" by the rest. Dion. Athen. iii. l. --- Though God had forbidden marriages with infidels, (C.) at least with those of Chanaan, (H.) a dispensation might be granted, (Ex. xxxiv. T. 2 K. iii. W.) for a greater good. Esther was not puffed up with her exaltation, and refrained from all forbidden meats. C. xiv. 15. C. --- If she be the Artystona of Herotous, (vii. 69.

H.) as it is most probable, (T.) her two sons, Arsames and Gobryas, had a command in the famous expedition of Xerxes. Usher, A. 3524. C.

Ver. 18. Servants. Sept. add, "seven days, and he magnified the nuptials of Esther." H. --- Rest, from labour. C. --- Sept. "remission to all his subjects," of tribute, as was sometimes done.

Herod. iii. 66. T. C. --- Gifts, on Esther. Chal. Malvenda.

Ver. 19. And. Sept. "But Mardochai," &c. H. --- They say nothing of the gifts, v.

18. --- Second.

The same process had been observed before, when Vasthi was chosen. C. ---

Mardochai was perhaps then one of the king's guards. H. v. 11. T. --- This second inquiry is here specified, to introduce the following account. M.

Ver. 20. Commandment. No one interrogated her, as she had been educated as Susa, and was taken for a Persian lady, v. 10. M.

Ver. 21. Bagathan, or Bagatha and Thara. C. xii. 1. One of the chief counsellors was called Bagatha. H. --- But these two were porters, (C.)

or guards, of the king, (Sept. Grot.) or of the treasury. Vatab. --- Some Gr. copies and the Chal.

insinuate that they were displeased at the advancement of Mardochai. The latter supposes that they meant also to poison Esther. C. --- It appears that they wished to make Aman king, (M.) and the detection was always resented by him.

C. xii. 6. C.

Ver. 22. Notice of it, from Barnabaz, a Jew in the service of one of them.

**Josephus, xi. 6. --- He might also hear some suspicious words. R.
Calom. W.**

**Ver. 23. King. Such histories were preserved with great care. 1 Esd. vi.
1. C. ---**

**Sept. "the king ordered a memorial to it to be kept in the royal library,
for the praise of Mardochai's good will."**

H. --- The latter also wrote an account. C. xii. 4.

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CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. Aman means, "a disturber." H. --- Who. Sept. add, "Bougaios, or Gogaaios." Gog designates Scythia, where Aman might have been born. Pliny (iv. 12.) places there the lake and river Ruges. But the Bugean, in Greek, may mean, "greatly puffed up:" or it may stand for Bagoas, "an eunuch," (Judith xii.

11.) like Putiphar. --- Agag, the king of Amalec. 1 K. xv. This title, like that of Macedonian, (C. xvi. 10.) is probably used out of contempt, as the Jews frequently styled their enemies, "race of Chanaan." Ezec. xvi. 3. Dan. xiii. 56. C.

--- Sulpitius takes Aman to have been a Persian. His Amalecite ancestors may have fled before Saul into Macedonia, though he himself resided in Persia, so as to belong to all those nations. T. M. ---

Throne. Thus were Joseph and Joakim exalted. Gen. xli. 40. and 4 K. xxv. 28. C.

--- The Persians gave places according to merit, (H.) or as a reward. Brisson.

Ver. 2. Worship him, with divine honours, as he required, in imitation of the kings. Judith iii. 13.

On certain solemn occasions, the latter at least exacted this respect from their subjects. But the pious Jews avoided appearing at such times, or the kings dispensed with them. The mere bending the knee, out of civil respect, would not have been objected to; and Mardochai says, he would not have refused to kiss the footsteps of Aman. C. xiii. 12. C. S. Tho. 2. 2. q. 84. T. --- But he could not give such worship as was claimed by the minor gods. W.

Ver. 4. Resolution. The did not mean to injure Mardochai, who had an employment at court. C.

xii. 5. C. --- Jew, and of course hindered by his religion from giving divine worship to any man.

M.

Ver. 6. Counted. Sept. "consulted how to exterminate all the Jews in the kingdom." --- Assuerus.

Heb. adds, "the people of Mardochai."

Ver. 7. Lot. The Persians were much addicted to divination. The superstitious Aman, though he would appear a deity, was to be regulated by lots!

Providence caused almost a whole year to intervene, before the cruel execution was to commence. C. --- Reason began to shew the futility of divination, (Cicero) but the Christian religion alone has been able to counteract its baneful influence. C. --- India is till much infected with it. Bernier. --- Phur.

Heb. "they cast Pur, that is the lot, before Aman." H. --- The explanation intimates that Pur is a Persian word. D. --- Yet Pagnin maintains that it means in Heb. "to crush," a wine-press, or vessel; and the lot, which is thrown therein. M. --- Tickets, with the names of the twelve months, were probably drawn; and after the month was thus determined, Aman put in the urn as many tickets as it had days, and was directed to pitch upon the 13th. Sept. have the 14th, both here and v. 13. C. --- How preposterous was the (H.) fury of this man, thus to decide upon the day before he had the king's leave! W.

Ver. 8. Another, as the ten tribes were from Juda, or rather (H.) they were scattered about the empire. C. --- Heb. "and dispersed; and their laws are different from all other people's; neither do they observe the king's laws: therefore it is not for the king's profit to tolerate them." H. --- These are the old calumnies repeated by Tacitus, (Hist. v.) and ably refuted by Josephus. c. Ap.

Almost all Israel still continued about Media. Few had taken advantage of the decree of Cyrus.

Ver. 9. Talents. Heb. &c. add, "of silver." M. --- If the Heb. talent be meant, this sum would be immense for an individual; (C.) though Aman might expect to raise it by the confiscation of the Jews' effects, v. 13. Some think he speaks of the Babylonian talent, on which supposition the sum would amount to twenty-one millions of French livres, (Bude. C.) or of the Attic one, which is worth half the Heb. talent. The king might thus be prevented from thinking that the tributes would be lessened. T.

Ver. 10. Ring, to transfer his power to him, for the time. Gen. xli. 42. Alexander gave his ring to Periccas, and was generally supposed thus to designate him for his successor. Justin. xii. See 1

Mac. vi. 14. 15.

Ver. 12. Lieutenants. Lit. "satraps." Heb. achashdarpene, "courtiers," (H.) or those who are in the presence of his majesty, or porters. C. --- They were entrusted with the care of the different provinces. H.

Ver. 13. Messengers. Lit. "runners." H. --- Posts were first established in Persia, and were the admiration of other nations, though nothing compared with ours, as they were not regular, nor for the people. They called these messengers Astandæ, or Angari. Mat. v. 41. Darius Condomanus was one of these postilions, before he came to the crown. C. --- At first the kings had people stationed on eminences, at a convenient distance, to make themselves heard, when they had to communicate some public news. Diod. xix. p. 680. --- Cyrus afterwards appointed horsemen, to succeed each other. Xenophon, Cyrop. viii.

--- Cæsar made some regulations on this head, which were perfected by Augustus and Adrian; but being neglected, Charlemagne strove to restore them: yet it is thought that the posts were not established, in France, till the reign of Louis XI. C.

Ver. 14. Letter. It should appear here, as it is in Gr. but the Heb. &c. omitting it, the Vulg. give it, C. xiii. 1.

Ver. 15. Jews. Heb. "but the city of Susan was in perplexity." Gr. "troubled." C.

--- Even the pagans could not view such a cruel decree, without horror. H.

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CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. Shewing. Sept. old Vulg. and Josephus, "a nation which has done no wrong, is to be cut off." The eastern nations were accustomed to such marks of sorrow. Jon. ii. 6. The citizens of Susa tore their garments, and cried aloud, for many days after the defeat of Xerxes. Herod. viii.

98. --- The domestics of Darius and Alexander tore also their hair, &c. after their masters' death.

Curt. iii. and xi.

Ver. 2. Sackcloth. Gr. adds, "and ashes." Such an appearance was deemed disrespectful. God forbids his priests to act thus. Lev. xxi. 1. See Gen. xli. 14.

Yet the miserable ought not to be entirely excluded from the king's presence, as he ought to be their protector.

Ver. 3. Edict. Lit. "dogma;: H. a word used in this sense, (Acts xv. 16.) and by Demosthenes,

&c. T. --- Mourning. The most effectual means of redress, is to do works of penance for past transgressions. 1 Cor. xi. 31. W.

Ver. 4. Her, concerning the unusual distress of one of the courtiers. They knew not, (M.) perhaps, that he was related to her. H.

Ver. 7. Money. Heb. "the sum of money." Sept. "then thousand talents."

Ver. 8. Entreat. Sept. "to put in a counter-petition, and entreat," &c. --- People.

Sept. add, "and country, remembering the days of thy lowly state, how thou wast fed by my hand; for Aman, the second after the king, has spoken against us, to have us destroyed. Call then upon the Lord, and speak to the king for us, and rescue us from death." H. --- This servant must have been very trusty, as the secret was confided to him, respecting the nation to which the queen belonged. M.

Ver. 11. Inner court, with regard to many others around, though there was one still more retired, (T.) where the king alone could enter. This admitted the light only by the door, before which hung a curtain, so that the king could see (C.) who came into the hall of audience, (H.) without being seen. None durst come even to this antichamber, without

being called. It was also death to appear with their hands out of their sleeves, (Cyrop. ii.) or to sit down, (Diod. xvii.) or look at any of the king's wives in the face, &c. Plut. Artax. --- This gloomy retirement was intended to keep up the idea of his majesty being something more than man. H. --- *Apud Persas persona regis, sub specie majestatis, occulitur.* Justin.

i. --- The king's secret cabinet (C.) resembled, in magnificence (C. xv. 9.) the description which Ovid has given us of the palace of the sun. T. --- It was covered with gold and precious stones. Here he continued, almost inaccessible, and business was despatched slowly. C. --- Agesilaus, king of Sparta, shewed how ridiculous these customs were, by acting quite the reverse, appearing frequently among his subjects, and granting their just requests without delay. Xenophon. --- Thirty. She might apprehend that the king's affection was beginning to cool. God was pleased thus to try her the more. H.

Ver. 13. Only. Aman would contrive to effect her ruin with the rest.

Ver. 14. Occasion. Wonderful confidence! Gr. "if thou wilt not hearken (C. to me; (H.) or, if thou obstinately despise) at this time, the Jews shall be assisted and protected by some," &c. H.

--- As this. So Joseph was raised up in Egypt, (C.) that he might save all his family. H.

Ver. 16. Pray. Heb. "fast." They might take some refreshment in the evening, (Lyran) of dried meats. Joseph. Grot. --- Few constitutions could have done without any thing. Yet after two nights and one full day were elapsed, Esther ventured to go to the king. C. v. 1. We have here another instance of places for prayer. Judith vi. 21. The old Vulg. has, "publish a fast, and tell the ancients to fast. Let the infants be kept from the breast during the night, and let no food be given to the oxen and other animals, while I and my maids shall fast," &c. Then at the end of this chapter, in the Sept. follow the prayers of Mardochai and of Esther, (C. xiii. 8. and C. xiv. H.) which is their proper place. C.

ESTHER 5

CHAPTER V.

Ver. 1. And. Instead of these two verses, the Sept. place (H.) what we have C.

xv. with some small variation from the present account in Heb. But there is nothing incompatible with the truth. C. --- The king might be at first displeased; but, seeing the effect which it had upon Esther, he might feel his former sentiments of love rekindle. C. T. --- House, or inner apartment, C. iv.

11. The throne was surprizingly magnificent, yet inferior to that of Solomon. 3

K. x. 18. C. --- It was formed of gold and precious stones, with a curtain over it of purple and other colours. Athen.

xi. 2.

Ver. 2. Golden. "It is not this golden sceptre which saves the kingdom," said Cyrus, "but faithful friends are the most true and secure sceptre for kings."

Cyrop. viii. C. --- Kissed. Heb.

"touched." H.

Ver. 3. Kingdom. C. vii. 2. This compliment only (C.) meant, that every rational (H.) request should be granted. Mar. vi. 23.

Ver. 4. Prepared. It was not prudent to declare her request, when many improper persons were present; and Aman was not there. M. --- She thought that the hilarity, occasioned by innocent feasting, (H.) might be a means of obtaining more effectually what she wanted. M. --- If the prudence of this world suggest much address, why may not virtue employ the same arts for good purposes? Esther had to obtain two great points; to make the king retract his edict, and to abandon his favourite. She is afraid therefore of being too hasty, (C.) and invites the king again, to increase by this delay his desire to of knowing her request, and that he might bind himself to grant it more effectually. W. --- She invites Aman alone, who would thus be more envied by the other courtiers; (Lyran) while she manifested an open disposition, and disdained to accuse the absent. T.

Ver. 6. Wine. The Persians did not drink till the end of the feast, (as the Turks are said to do at present. Tavernier) when they fall upon wine without any moderation. Ælian, Hist. xii. 1.

Ver. 11. Children. After military glory, this was deemed the greatest. The king sent presents yearly to those who had most children. Herod. i. 136.

Ver. 12. But me. It was thought very singular, when Artaxerxes invited his own brothers. Plut.

--- But when he also admitted a foreigner, the nobility became jealous, as that honour was reserved for the king's relations. Athen. i. --- Dine, or feast. Only one meal was taken, (Herod.

vii. 120.) and that in the evening. C.

Ver. 13. Whereas. Sept. "all these things do not satisfy me, while I behold," &c.

Such is the insatiable nature of ambition! H. --- Gate. He does not clearly mention that he wanted to be adored. M.

Ver. 14. High. This was to increase the shame. Hence Galba condemned a Roman citizen to be hung on a high white cross. Sueton. ix. --- The Jews formerly burned a man in effigy with a cross, pretending to do it in detestation of Aman, but in reality to deride our Saviour, till the emperors forbade the custom. C. ix. 21. C. Just. and Theodos. C.

ESTHER 6

CHAPTER VI.

Ver. 1. Sleep. Anxious what Esther could desire. Sept. "But the Lord removed sleep from the king that night." H. --- Providence watched over the welfare of his people. --- Chronicles. The king took particular care (C.) to have their benefactors mentioned in history and rewarded.

Herod. viii. 85. Assuerus had not recourse to musicians, &c. wisely (T.) reflecting that history is the most pleasing and useful amusement. Cicero, &c.

T. --- God directed him on this occasion, as his eye never sleepeth. Josephus.

W.

Ver. 3. No reward at all. He received some presents from the king; (C. xii. 5.) but these were so inconsiderable in the opinion of the courtiers, that they esteemed them as nothing at all; (Ch.) and they were not specified in the history. C.

Ver. 4. Inner court. To which only such favourites and noblemen had access.

Herod. iii. 72. and 84. This king had himself come thither with six others, when they conspired to destroy Smerdis.

Heb. &c. read, "the outward court," in which Aman was, till he heard the king was awake, and called for him. C.

Ver. 8. Apparel. Gr. "of byssus," which was very superb. C. xv. 9. The king alone could wear the tiara upright. The nobles wore it hanging backwards.

Cyrus allowed his nobility to appear in purple, but he would have only his own robes striped with white. Cyrop. viii. Curt. iii. --- The kings often made presents of garments, &c. to ambassadors, and to those who were styled "their relations." --- Horse: 200 such appeared in the train of Cyrus, with golden bits, which none were permitted to use without special leave. --- Head. Gr. seems to refer this to the horse, which might indeed have a sort of crown. But the golden one was more probably worn by the person honoured. C. viii. 15.

Ver. 9. Nobles. Lit. "tyrants." H. --- But this word was not formerly odious; as it only denoted

"a prince." Pars mihi pacis erit dextram tetigisse tyranni. Æneid vii. --- Abuse of power caused it to become hateful. T.

Ver. 10. Spoken. The distinction was not for one day only. Mardochai might afterwards wear the tiara, &c. God thus clearly manifested that he would resist the proud, and give grace to the humble. S. Jam. iv. 6. The exaltation of Joseph in Egypt, (C.) and lately of Daniel at the court at Babylon, (T.) was hardly less wonderful. Gen. xli. Dan. vi. C. --- We may easily conceive the astonishment which would fill the breast of Aman, as well as of Mardochai, on this occasion.

The Greek published by Usher, has expressed these sentiments; (H.) and the Chaldee has added many embellishments, which are of no authority. C.

Ver. 12. Covered. To hide his shame, (T.) as Demosthenes did, when the people kissed him.

Plutarch. See 2 K. xv. Ezec. xii. 6.

Ver. 13. Wise men. Probably the magi, who concluded, from the first miscarriage, that he undertaking would prove abortive, (C.) as they were also informed of God's protection given repeatedly to the Jews. Sept. "because the living God is with him." Chal. They might have heard of the fate of Sennacherib and of Holofernes, (C.) or of God's promises, (Gen. xiii. and xv.) unless they were guided by human prudence. W.

Ver. 14. As. Thus from morning till noon, (T.) or night, had this petty god (H.) been forced to stoop to the meanest offices, and durst not say a word in opposition. T. --- He would gladly have now absented himself from the feast, (M.) with the idea of which he had been enraptured. H.

ESTHER 7

CHAPTER VII.

Ver. 1. Drink. Wine was only used at great feasts. Eccli. xxxi. 17. Water was served up first, from the river Choaspes only. The king and his eldest son were allowed to drink of "the golden waters," of which they alone had 70 fountains.

Athen. xii. 2. --- Their wine was brought from Chelbon, near Damascus. Id. i. 22.

Ezec. xxvii. 18. C.

Ver. 3. People. She was more concerned for these than for half of the kingdom.

Hence all fasted and prayed, and Esther obtained their deliverance. W.

Ver. 4. Perish. Three terms of the same import express the greatness of the misery. H. --- King.

Whose revenue will be greatly impaired, (C.) and character injured, for having given such power to a monster. H. --- The kings of Persia had taken many precautions not to be thus deluded, having appointed officers, who were styled "the eyes and ears" of the king, purposely to obtain all necessary information. But these eyes were often darkened; these ears were often deaf, (C.) and unwilling to act with fidelity; (H.) though their diligence in make secret transactions known, caused the people to look upon their kings as gods. Apul.

Mund. Cyrop. viii. C.

Ver. 5. What. Heb. "where, who durst entertain this design?" H.

Ver. 6. Astonished. Horror of a guilty conscience is the first punishment. S.

Chrys. W.

Ver. 7. Set. Heb. "of the palace," (H.) belonging to the queen. C.

Ver. 8. My own. Heb. "will he force...in the house?" H. --- Those who know with what jealousy the Persians treated their wives, so at to punish with death those who crossed the road before the queens, (Plut. Artax.) or touched them, will not wonder at the indignation of Assuerus, (C.) though his suspicions were groundless. H. --- Aman wished to incline the queen to shew clemency, (M.) and intercede for him. He threw himself as a suppliant at her feet, as she lay on the bed at table. H. --- Face. His crime was notorious; no trial was requisite, and the kings could treat their subjects as slaves. It was customary to cover the faces of those who were led to execution. Philotas was thus conducted into the presence of Alexander. Curt. vi.

Ver. 9. Harbona. Cr. "Bougathan." H. --- He had been to call Aman to the feast.

Jos. --- Little dependance is to be had on false friendship, when a man is disgraced. W. --- Upon it. His body was perhaps afterwards exposed in the street. C. xvi. 18. It is not clear that he was nailed to the cross, though this custom prevailed in the country. 1 Esd. vi. 11. Alexander crucified many satraps. Curt. ix. --- The old Vulg. observes that the wife and ten children of Aman suffered with him. C. ix. 6. C.

ESTHER 8

CHAPTER VIII.

Ver. 1. House, and furniture. Sept. "all the possessions of Aman, the devil,"

(accuser, &c. H.) which were confiscated for treason; and no one had a better title than the queen, whose life had been in such danger. Yet she did not touch the estates of the children, v. 13. C. ix. 10. --- King.

in the place of Aman. C. ix. 4. and x. 3. --- Uncle, or cousin. C.

Ver. 2. Aman. It seems the traitor had hitherto kept possession of it, and sealed the king's edicts, as Mardochai was now to do, v. 8. --- House. Heb. &c. "of Aman," to whom it had belonged. C.

Ver. 3. Down. such reverence is due to God's representatives, whatever heretics may say. Jude 8.

Ver. 5. To him. Heb. adds, "and I be pleasing in his eyes," which had been expressed just before.

Yet she might insist on this point, as it shewed a greater regard for the king's pleasure. --- I beseech. Heb. "let it be written, to reverse the device of Aman, the son," &c. H. --- When the edict was not sealed by the nobles, it might be altered; (C. i. 19.) and at any rate, when the king had been visibly imposed upon, in an affair of such consequence, justice dictated that it should not be enforced. C.

Ver. 7. Durst. Heb. "laid." He had sufficiently manifested his intention to destroy them, though he had not been able to injure any one. H.

Ver. 8. This. Heb. "no one may reverse the letter," &c.

Ver. 9. Third. Rom. Sept. "first...Nisan," ten days after Aman's decree, who seems to have been presently brought to judgment. Yet two whole months might easily elapse, (C.) and ten days more, before this

contrary edict was dispatched. H. --- The day of slaughter was still remote. M.

Ver. 10. Posts, who had a right to make use of any person's horse, &c. M. ---

Who. Prot. "on horseback, and riders on mules, camels, and young dromedaries." H. --- The original terms greatly embarrass interpreters. C. ---

Sept. have simply, "he sent the writings by letter-carriers, ordering them to follow their own laws in every city, to help themselves, and treat their adversaries and opponents as they pleased, on one day...the 13th...of Adar.

This is a copy," &c.

C. xvi. H.

Ver. 11. Spoil. This was retaliating, as they were to have been treated in like manner. C. ---

Such were the barbarous customs of the country. H. --- It might not still be lawful thus to involve the innocent with the guilty, though the king did not ill in allowing the Jews to stand up in their own defence. 2 K. xxi. 6. Some think that they were only to prevent the execution of the former edict, which could not be revoked. See C. iii. C. --- A form of trial was observed. C. xvi. 20.

M.

Ver. 15. Cloak. The kings wore one of purple, over their purple and white tunic.

Cyrop. viii. ---

Gr. have "diadem." C.

Ver. 17. Ceremonies. Becoming acquainted with the sanctity of the law, and the protection which God gave to his people. M. --- Heb. "the Jews had joy and gladness, a feast, and a good day, and many of the people of the land became Jews; for the fear of the Jews," &c. Prot. H.

ESTHER 9

CHAPTER IX.

Ver. 1. As. Heb. "(which is the month of Adar) when the king's command and edict drew near to be executed, in that day when the enemies of the Jews hoped to have power over them, (though it turned out that the Jews had dominion over those who hated them)" H. --- To revenge, &c. The Jews, on this occasion, by authority from the king, were made executioners of the public justice, for punishing by death a crime worthy of death, viz. a malicious conspiracy for extirpating their whole nation; (Ch.) so inscrutable are the judgments of God, who never wholly abandoned his people! The old Vulg.

passes over the first 19 verses, with the 24th, 25th, and 28th. C. --- In this whole history we cannot but admire the Providence of God. W.

Ver. 3. Extolled. Prot. "helped." Sept. "the king's secretaries honoured the Jews." H.

Ver. 6. Sons. It seems as if they had been slain with their father, v. 10. See C.

vii. 9. C. --- Yet, as the contrary would appear from C. xvi. 18, we may suppose that they were at least H.

imprisoned till this time, for a more exemplary punishment, while all the rest of the family perished with Aman. Serar. Salien. M. --- These are the kindred, specified nine months before.

C. xvi. T. --- Some Masorets childishly (H.) write these ten names one over another, and with greater and lesser letters, to shew that they were hung one above another, and that the guilt of all was not the same, but the youngest son was the most malicious. Kennicott, Ver. 10. Goods, in any place, (T.) that they might not appear to be actuated by the desire of riches, (C.) to fall upon the innocent. How often does this fatal cause blind Christian conquerors!

The sons of Aman were married, and had separate establishments. C. viii. 1.

Ver. 13. Susan. Aman's influence had been the greatest there, and had stirred up many enemies of the Jews, who were to be carefully sought out. H. --- If we should consider only the dictates of clemency, we should think that the Jews were too eager in their revenge. But when we reflect, that their enemies had intended to destroy them all, and to seize their effects, we shall allow that they did not exceed the limits of justice, as they acted by royal authority, and abstained from touching any effects of the deceased. C. --- In the capital, 800

men fell victims to their fury. But as the citizens of that place were probably the most guilty, we must not imagine that other cities would be treated with the like severity. H. --- Gibbets, for a terror to the wicked. M. --- This disgrace was not unusual. C. xvi.18. Polycrates was treated thus. Herod. iii. 125.

Ver. 16. Lives. In many cases they would probably be attacked, as Aman's edict was perhaps still in force, as well as that of Mardochai. Hence both parties would be upon the watch. H. ---

Seventy-five. Rom. Sept. has only 15,000. Complut. 10,035. C.

Ver. 19. Meats, not only to the poor, but to all their friends, v. 22, and 2 Esd. viii.

10. C.

Ver. 21. Receive. Prot. "establish this among them, that they should keep the 14th...yearly." 2

Mac. xv. 37. H. --- None were obliged to keep more than one of these days, according to their respective dwellings. The 14th was for the provinces, the 15th for the Jews of Susan, v. 18. T.

C. W. --- Yet it would seem that both days were enjoined, v. 27, 28. H. --
- The Jews still observe, them, as they gratify their vanity and vindictive spirit. The 13th is kept a rigid fast, for all above sixteen, for twenty-four hours, during which they eat nothing. C. --- If that day should be a sabbath, or its eve, they fast on the 11th or 12th. Drusius. --
- The day before the festival they give alms to their poor brethren, enjoining them to consume the whole in making good cheer.

Each person must then contribute the half sicle, (Ex. xxx. 13.) which is bestowed on those who undertake a pilgrimage to the land of promise. At night, when the feast commences, they light the lamps, and begin to read the Book of Esther, as soon as the stars appear. They use an old parchment MS.

roll, and, in the five places, the reader shouts with all his might, running over the names of the ten sons of Aman with all haste, to shew that they all died in a moment. Whenever Aman is mentioned, the children beat the benches with mallets; and formerly they used to strike at a stone, on which his name was cut, till it broke, v. 31. After the lecture, they take a repast at home. Early the next morning they return to the synagogue, and read the account of Amalec from the Pentateuch, and repeat the Book of Esther, with the aforesaid ceremonies. The rest of the day they spend in merriment. Their teachers allow them to drink till they are unable to distinguish the name of Aman from that of Mardochai. Basnage, vi. 15. --- They also change clothes, in contradiction to the law; (Deut. xxii. 5.) and were

formerly accustomed to crucify a man of straw, which they burnt with the cross, till Christian emperors put a stop to them; as it was concluded, from their curses, &c. that they had an eye to our Saviour. C. See C. v. 14. H.

Ver. 25. And. Heb. "But when she came." Sept. "and how he came to the king, asking leave to hang Mardochai. But his machinations against the Jews, turned upon his own head; and so," &c.

H.

Ver. 28. Ceremonies. The king also enjoined (C. xvi. 22.) all his subjects (T.) to keep a day of rejoicing, (H.) as the death of Aman was deemed a public benefit.

C.

Ver. 29. Second. The first might be the edict, (C. viii. 9.) or else the provisional establishment of the festival, as it could not have general authority till it was ratified by the high priest; after which, this second letter was dispatched. C. ---

Sept. "and queen Esther, daughter of Aminadab,

&c....wrote all that they had done, and also the confirmation of the epistle of Phourai." They should say Phurim, as the former word means "guards." Heb.

"wrote with all authority, to confirm this second letter of Purim;" (Prot. H.) or rather, "this letter, Phurim, of which this is a copy." The Rom. Sept. only add for this and their advice; (C. Ed. Alex. "for their health and counsel.") and Esther established for ever, and wrote as a memorial: My nation," &c. H.

Ver. 30. Peace: receive these glad tidings, and faithfully observe the injunctions. C.

Ver. 31. Fasts and cries. See v. 21. C. --- Prot. "the matters of their fastings and their cry: and the decree of Esther confirmed these matters of Purim, and it was written in the book." H. ---

This feast, instituted by Mardochai, was accepted and observed by the Jews as a constitution agreeable to, and not contrary to the law. Deut. iv. 2. and xii.

32. W.

ESTHER 10

CHAPTER X.

Ver. 1. Land. He conquered many countries on the continent, and several to which he could not come but by water, which the Jews call islands, whether they were surrounded on all sides by the sea or not. Heb. has not the word all: but as the expressions are indefinite, they are usually taken in this sense. Yet we must not suppose, that the dominion of Assuerus extended over the whole world, no more than that of the Romans, who were styled masters of it. Before this king, the provinces had not paid tribute, but gave what they judged proper.

But Darius laid a heavy tribute upon all, that, when half was afterwards remitted, they might esteem it a favour. The Persians hence looked upon him as a trafficker: kapelos. Herod. iii. 89. and iv. 44. and vi. 7. &c. C. ---

Providence punished them for thirsting after the possessions and blood of the Jews. T.

Ver. 3. Seed. Benjamin (Itin.) informs us, that both he and the queen were buried in the chief city of the Medes, which he calls "the great Hamda;"

perhaps the province Mardochæa, (or Amordakai. Ptol. v. 20.) near the Persian gulf, may have been called after this statesman. T.

Ver. 4. Then Mardochai, &c. Here S. Jerom adviseth the reader, that what follows is not in the Hebrew; but is found in the Sept. Greek edition, which the 72 interpreters translated out of the Hebrew, or added by the inspiration of the Holy Ghost. Ch. --- He says, "What is extant in Heb. I have faithfully translated.

What follows I found in the Vulg. edition, contained in the Greek language and character: and in the mean time, or waving all dispute for the present, (interim) this little chapter was inserted at the end of the book, which, according to our custom, we have marked with an

obel or spit." H. --- These fragments (H.) which the Sept. might have in Heb. or wrote by inspiration, (W.) are not in Chal. or Syr. and the old Latin version, taken from the Greek (C.) of Lysimachus, (C. xi. 1. H.) is inserted by S. Jerom. C. --- Things. He attributes the salvation of the Jews to God alone. H. --- Reflecting on the fall of Aman, (T.) he recollects a dream which he had formerly had. H.

Ver. 5. A dream. This dream was prophetic and extraordinary, otherwise the general rule is, not to observe them. Ch.

Ver. 6. And was. Sept. "and there was light, and the sun and much water." The light enabled him to discern the progress of the little fountain. Yet it was not absurd that the water should appear luminous, like the sun, as it was intended to shew the wonderful exaltation of Esther. H. --- She extinguished a great fire, which threatened ruin. M.

Ver. 10. Lots. Alluding to the Purim of Aman; (C. Capel.) or rather these are only mentioned, v.

13. Houbigant. --- Gr. "He had therefore made two lots...and the two lots came to the hour and time and day of judgment before God, and for all nations." H.

Ver. 11. Time. From all eternity (T.) God had ordained to save his people; and this he declared to his servants, by shewing him two lots. H. --- This became more intelligible after the event, (T.) like other predictions. H.

Ver. 12. Mercy. Gr. "justified." But this often means, shewed mercy. Ex. xxxiv. 7.

C. --- The book concludes in Greek with the first verse, which we have in the following chapter, though some editions seem (H.) to have had that remark (D.) of the Alexandrian Jews, (C.) at the head of the book. H.

ESTHER 11

CHAPTER XI.

Ver. 1. Cleopatra. So the kings and queens of Egypt were styled after Lagus; whence we can only gather, that this translation was brought after the reign of Alexander, and most probably under Philometer, the sixth of his successors.

He was a great admirer of the Jews, and employed one Dositheus as his general, who might be the priest here mentioned; as such an office was not incompatible with his character. T. --- Usher is of this opinion. See Jos. con.

Ap. ii. But would he then be mentioned as if he had been a person almost unknown? C. --- We may say that he only raised himself by merit, after this time. H. --- Philometer reigned 177 years, B.C. The Sept. (C.) who gave their version in the 7th year of Philadelphus, (S. Epip.) were not the authors of the Greek edition of Esther; (C.) or perhaps, they may have adopted this of Lysimachus, (Huet. D.) as far as it went; the letter of Purim being only the groundwork of this history. If they did, Lysimachus must have lived before the time of Philometer; or what seems as probable, (H.) that the celebrated version has been made by different authors, and at different times. Hody. ---

Jerusalem. Here S. Jerom subjoins, "This beginning was also in the Vulg.

edition, which does not occur in Hebrew or any interpreter," (H.) except the Sept. W. --- This must be referred to what follows.

Ver. 2. Second year, the same when Darius gave an edict for building the temple, (1 Esd. iv. T.) and the year before the great feast, (C. i. 3.) when the Jews little thought of such danger hanging over them. C. W. -- - Benjamin. C. ii.

5. we read Jemini, which shews that they have the same import. T.

Ver. 3. Court, afterwards. C. --- He had a dream in the second year. Houbigant.

Ver. 4. Juda. This has been noticed already. C. ii. 5. But we need not be surprized at such repetitions. We find the like in the books of Moses, and 1 K.

xvi. 10. and xvii. 12. &c. H. --- S.

Jerom says, "Librum Esther variis translatoribus constat esse vitiatum;" or, various historical documents may have been improperly inserted in the Greek, though they be true; and therefore S.

Jerom has rightly removed the to the end. Houbigant.

Ver. 7. Cry. While Aman was full of indignation against Mardochai, and the latter would not submit to adore him, the various nations of the empire were instigated to fall upon the Jews. H.

Ver. 10. Waters. Esther, by her tears, extinguished the rising flame. W.

Ver. 11. Rose up. A bright sun (T.) represented God, (C.) or the king. Grotius.

Ver. 12. Signify. He was convinced that it was from heaven. C.

ESTHER 12

CHAPTER XII.

Ver. 1. At that time, is not in Greek. Capellus therefore argues in vain against the Greek author, as if this event took place in the 2d year.

Houbigant. --- The expression often occurs in Scripture, without determining the precise time. H.

Ver. 2. When. Gr. "for he heard their deliberations." --- Told, by the mouth of Esther. C. ii. 21.

H.

Ver. 5. Palace, as an officer. --- Presents, of small value. C. --- The king had inquired, (Gr. C.

vi. 3.) "What glory or favour have we done to Mardochai? and the ministers replied: Thou hast done nothing to him," to honour him as he deserves.

Ver. 6. Bugite, may refer to some town of Macedon. C. iii. 1. --- Honour. Yet he might be still more exalted, after the conspiracy was detected; (Houbig.) as the king little suspected that he was concerned in it. H. --- Death. It is thought that they wished to place Aman, or some Macedonian, on the throne. C. xvi. 12. 14.

C. --- This reason for the malevolence of Aman, might be unknown to Mardochai. C. xiii. 12. Houbigant. --- The former was either a favourer of traitors, or perhaps of the same conspiracy. W.

ESTHER 13

CHAPTER XIII.

Ver. 1. "Hitherto," S. Jerom observes, "the preface extends. What follows, was placed in that part of the volume where it is written, And they, &c. (C. iii. 13.

where the edict should naturally appear. C.) which we have found only in the Vulg. edition." H. --- Josephus produces this edict at length, but with some variations, (C.) which are of no importance. H.

Ver. 2. World. This is an exaggeration. Princes are flattered with high titles, but none more so than those of the East. C. --- Quietly. Lit. "in silence." Gr.

"undisturbed by the stormy billows, (akumantous) at all times; and that the kingdom might be rendered quiet, and the roads unmolested, to the very extremities; that peace, which is desired by all men, may be renewed."

How amiable are these dispositions, which ought to be cherished by all princes! We might then hope soon to see peace restored. H.

Ver. 3. After. Gr. "of all kingdoms as a reward, Aman shewed me," &c.

Josephus, "the second after me, for his fidelity and confirmed good will." C. ---

It is a great hurt for a king to be governed by one counsellor. Prov. xv. 22. W.

Ver. 4. A people. Gr. "a certain perverse people, mixed with every tribe through," &c. --- New.

Gr. "opposite to those of every nation, which always casteth aside the edicts of the kings, so that we cannot extend to them that upright and blameless dominion which we exercise over you."

Ver. 6. Second. Gr. "our second father." C. --- Compl. "the second after us, shall be all extirpated by," &c. H. --- This king is represented as very stupidly giving orders for the destruction of a nation which he never names; (Capel.) but he intimates that Aman would do it, in whom he placed the most unbounded confidence. H. --- If the latter had any suspicions of the queen's being of that nation, he might very prudently abstain from mentioning the Jews even to the king, contenting himself with describing them so that they would easily be known by his agents; and, in effect, the king sufficiently pointed out the Jews, by saying that they followed laws different from all the world. Houbigant. --- Infidels generally represent them as a wicked race, enemies to all but their own nation. Tacitus, &c. --- We need not wonder if Catholics be painted in the same colours, as the devil is still the same. H. ---

Fourteenth. Josephus has the same day, though the 13th is specified in Heb.

&c. (C. iii. 12.) and in the Gr. and Vulg. C. xvi.

20. We must, therefore, allow that the Jews might be slaughtered on both days, or that the Greek is incorrect in this place. C. --- Salien thinks it would not be lawful to spare the Jews any longer than the 14th day; (M.) or the carnage was to cease on the 14th, as it did at Susa. C. ix. 17. 19. T.

Ver. 7. Hell. Prot. "grave." The king only wanted to send them out of this world.

At the end of this verse, S. Jerom says, "Hitherto is given the copy of the epistle. I found what follows after that place where we read, So Mardochai, &c.

(C. iv. 17.) yet it is not in Heb. nor does it appear in any of the interpreters." H.

--- He means, Aquila, &c. For he plainly asserts before, that it was in the Septuagint, which he calls the Vulgate; and all know that his

version was taken from the Heb.

The Church reads this prayer of Mardochai, (T.) in the mass, against pagans, (W.) and 21st Sunday after Pentecost, &c. so that this is a part of Scripture which the Council of Trent will not suffer to be rejected. T.

Ver. 14. To a man; "as if," says Capellus, "the salutation and civil honour be not quite different from adoration and religious worship, which must be given to God alone. Neither did Haman demand religious adoration, but only salutation and civil honour... To bend the knee is frequently used in civil honour, nor is it necessarily understood of religious worship." May our English Protestants deign to borrow this grain of common sense from one their foreign brethren, when they attempt to impugn the respect given by Catholics to the saints. H. --- "We grant that Aman did not require religious worship: but as the civil respect which he claimed, was to be performed in the same manner as the Jews worshipped God, Mardochai would not wound his own conscience, or that of his people." Houbigant. --- Yet it is by no means clear that Aman did not insist on being worshipped as a god. It is evident that Mardochai understood him, at least, in that light. C. iii. 2. H.

Ver. 17. Inheritance. Lit. "line," (H.) as it was usual to measure land with lines.

M.

ESTHER 14

CHAPTER XIV.

Ver. 1. Fearing. Gr. "caught in the agony of death." The old Vulgate has many variations in this chapter. C. --- This prayer should be placed after that of Mardochai, at the end of C. iv. M.

Ver. 2. Ointments. Gr. "instead of the proud sweets, she filled her head with ashes and dust."

Such as might be soon cleansed again. H. --- Torn. Gr. "curled hair," (strapton tricheon. H.) some of which she cut off. See Lev. xix. 27. and xxi. 5. Houbig.

Ver. 4. Hands; very imminent. I am ready to expose my life. Ps. cxviii. 109. C.

Ver. 5. Heard. Old Vulg. often repeats, "from the books of my fathers;" adducing the various instances of protection which God had shewn to his people, Noe, Abraham, Jonas, the three children, Daniel, Ezechias, and Anna: which intimates that Esther made the sacred books the subject of her frequent meditations, as good people ought to do. H.

Ver. 7. For. Gr. "since we have extolled," &c. Esther had not been guilty herself of this prevarication; but too many of the people had. H.

Ver. 8. But. Gr. Compl. "Yea, thou hast placed (or rather as the Alex. MS. reads, they have placed) their hands upon the hands of their idols, (H. making league together. C.) to tear away the decree of thy mouth," (H.) and to put in execution the projects of (M.) the devil. H.

Ver. 10. Idols. Gr. "of the vain things, and to render wonderful for ever," &c.

Ver. 11. Not idols, as they are often here designated, (C. and 1 Cor. viii.) being only the imaginations of men. W. --- Destroy. Gr. "Make an

example of the man, who had begun (H.

evils. C.) against us." H. --- She throws the blame upon Aman, and not upon her husband. C.

Ver. 12. Gods. Gr. "nations, and Lord of all power." H.

Ver. 13. Lion. This expression seems not sufficiently respectful. Capellus. ---

But why might not Esther use it with regard to one, who was raging against her people more than any lion, as S.

Paul applies it to Nero, probably after her example? Houbigant. 2 Tim. iv. 17. ---

David also thus styles Saul and his persecutors in general. Ps. vii. 3. &c. C.

Ver. 15. Stranger. Only those near Chanaan were forbidden to marry; and S.

Paul commends Eunice, who had espoused an infidel. Capel. --- But this was not the reason of his commendation; for he ordains, Bear not the yoke with infidels. A pious woman might, therefore, very well refrain from such contracts, to which the Jews, at this time, were in a manner forced.

Still Esther might have a conjugal love for her husband, (Houbig.) though she would have preferred to marry one poorer of her own religion; and here she only submitted to the designs of God, in raising her to such an elevated station. M.

Ver. 16. Sign. The diadem. It was no sin to wear it. Capel. --- What then? May not a pious prince despise such ornaments, raising his mind above them?

Houbig. --- Silence, when I am alone. Nothing could give us a higher idea of Esther's virtue and greatness of soul, as her elevation did not

make her forget herself. C.

Ver. 17. Me. Ought she to have been thus affected towards her husband?

Capel. ---

Undoubtedly: as the meats and the wine had been offered to idols. Houbig.

ESTHER 15

CHAPTER XV.

Ver. 1. S. Jerom says, "These additions I also found in the Vulg. edition." H. ---

This history is more succinctly related. C. v. C. --- Her. Lit. "And he commanded her (no doubt Mardochai did Esther) to go," &c. The parenthesis was added by S. Jerom. H.

Ver. 2. Remember. This is not here in Greek, but more regularly. C. iv. 8. C.

Ver. 3. Death. S. Jerom subjoins, I found there "also what follows."

Ver. 4. Day. Gr. adds, "as she had finished her prayer." --- Wore. Lit. "of her ornament." But the Greek has properly, (H.) "of her mourning." M.

Ver. 5. Glittering. Gr. "and was resplendent after," &c.

Ver. 6. As if. Gr. "as being delicate. But the other followed, holding up her garment. But she, blushing in the height of her beauty, with a cheerful and most lovely countenance, felt the pressure of fear on her heart."

Ver. 10. Eyes. Gr. adds, "with glory," with which he was surrounded. This made him at first resent the coming in of women uncalled, till her perceived Esther, and saw her fainting. H. ---

Capellus would represent this conduct of the king as ridiculous, and contrary to the true history.

But this is false: and he improperly renders *agoniasas*, *regem concidisce* & *animo defecisse*; as if the king had fallen down in a swoon; whereas it only means that he experienced those sentiments of anxiety which every good husband would do on the like occasion. Houbig. C. v. 2. ---

Assuerus had at first only perceived the maid, who went before the queen, and the hall was very spacious. Houbig. --- Pale. Gr. "in a fainting-fit, and she leaned upon the head of her maid, (Abra.) who was going before."

Ver. 11. All. Gr. "being in an agony, he," &c. --- Caressed. Gr. "comforted her with words of peace, and said to her, What," &c. H.

Ver. 12. Brother; (united by the closest bands. Cant. viii. 1. C.) Gr. "Take courage, Thou," &c.

Ver. 13. Others, is not expressed; (H.) and Esther might well suppose that she was included, as she probably was, (C. iv. 11. Capellus) though the king now altered his mind. Houbig. --- Gr.

"our decree is common," made for our subjects. According to the Roman law, the empress enjoyed the like privileges as her husband. C.

Ver. 14. Then. Gr. "and taking the golden septre, he laid," &c.

Ver. 15. Why. Gr. "speak to me; and she said to him." H.

Ver. 16. Angel. The Chaldees had the same notion as the Jews about angels; and the latter never shewed more devotion towards them than after the captivity, when the Scriptures speak more plainly on this subject. Jacob compares his brother Esau to an angel, (C.) or to God. Gen. xxxiii.

10. See also 1 K. xxix. 9. and 2 K. xiv. 17. H.

Ver. 18. Almost. Lit. "almost dead." Gr. "she fell in a fainting fit."

ESTHER 16

CHAPTER XVI.

Ver. 1. From India to Ethiopia. That is, who reigneth from India to Ethiopia. Ch.

--- S. Jerom writes, "The copy of the letter of king Artaxerxes, which he wrote in favour of the Jews, to all the provinces of his kingdom, which also is not in the Heb. volume." It should properly occur, C.

viii. 13, as it does in Greek. The edict is well written in that language, which has induced a belief that it is not a translation. C. --- But that is no very strong argument. H.

Ver. 2. Princes. Gr. "Beneficent." Luke xxii. 25. C. --- Gr. "Many of those who have been the most honoured by the kindness of the beneficent, have increased in folly, and not only endeavour to injure our subjects, but, unable to hear the weight of favours, devise schemes against their benefactors."

Ver. 4. Neither. Gr. "And they not only take away gratitude from among men, but elated with good fortune, which they had not before experienced, they flatter themselves that they will escape the sentence of an all-seeing God, levelled against the wicked." H. --- Artaxerxes insists with reason on the ingratitude of Aman, as it was a crime punishable by their laws; (Cyrop. i.

Brisson ii. p. 250.) and the Persian kings were particularly careful to reward those who had done them good. C.

Ver. 5. And. Gr. "For oftentimes fair speeches, or (H.) revenge, (paramuthia.

Isai. i. 24. C.) has made several of those who have been in authority, and entrusted with the affairs of their friends, partakers in the spilling of innocent blood, and involved them in irremediable calamities, by the

wicked craft of those who purposely lead astray the unsuspecting benevolence of governors."

H.

--- Josephus (xi. 3.) gives nearly the same sense: (C.) "For some of these, being placed in power by their friends, and bearing a private hatred towards some, have deluded their princes by false reasons, and by accusations have persuaded them to stir up the wrath of those who have done no wrong; on which account, they have been in danger of perishing." This author was not, therefore, unacquainted with the fragment, or part of the history, before us. H.

Ver. 7. Proved. Gr. "may be seen, not so much from ancient histories, as we have observed, but more so, if ye examine what wicked things have been done recently, by the fault (or cruelty) of those who have been unworthily in command: and if ye attend, in future, that we may without trouble settle our kingdom in peace for all men. For though we make some changes, yet we make a discernment of what falls under our inspection, and other things with more equity." He intimates that the former decree of Aman had been subreptitious.

Ver. 10. Now. Gr. "For as Aman, of Amadathos, a Macedonian, a stranger to the real blood of the Persians, and of a very different character from our goodness, and who, though a stranger to us, partook of that philanthropy which we have for every nation, insomuch as to be styled," &c. H.

--- At this time the Macedonians were hardly known. Capel. --- But this may be questioned, as their kingdom was of ancient date. Houbigant. --
- some think that the Asiatic Macedonians may be designated.
Hardouin. Pliny v. 30. 31. ---

These, however, may have been so called only after the conquests of Alexander. This king fought against the Greeks, of whom the Macedonians formed a part. T. --- The name may here be placed only for a stranger. C. ---

Staining. The faults of ministers often redound to the disgrace of those who employ them. M.

Ver. 12. Life. This he might only suspect; (C.) or his machinations with the two porters, might be declared after his disgrace. H. --- Capellus thinks it improbable that Aman intended to murder the queen, as he was so much elated at being invited by her to a feast, &c. But his schemes were various: (Houbig.) and who can pretend to say what would have satisfied his cruelty and ambition? H.

Ver. 14. Without. Gr. "abandoned." H. --- Macedonians; or to himself, who was of that nation.

It was not necessary to call over forces, as Capellus would suppose.

Ver. 16. God. Cyrus had styled him, "the God of heaven." Houbig. 1 Esd. i. H. ---

But Darius embraced the true religion, and adored God. T. --- Fathers.

"Hystaspes was not a descendant of Cyrus, but he was of the same royal stock." Just. i. Herod. iii. 85. --- And is. Gr. "by the best disposition. You will therefore do well not to make use of the letter, sent by Aman." The edict could not be repealed; (Capel. Houbig.) though this seems doubtful, when it was manifestly subreptitious, (M.) unjust, and not sealed by the nobles. C.

Ver. 18. Gibbets. Aman was thus treated, several months before his ten sons.

C. vii. 10. and ix.

6. Yet all the family might still be seen hanging, when this edict was dispatched. Houbigant suspects that this and the following verses properly belong to the letter written by Esther and Mardochai. The arguments are not very cogent. H.

Ver. 19. Laws. This was privilege often desired. Joseph. xiii.4.

Ver. 20. Kill. Gr. "take revenge on those who in the day of distress shall fall upon them, on the 13th."

Ver. 21. Sadness. Gr. "destruction of his chosen race, into," &c. H.

Ver. 22. Days. A festival was kept in memory of the destruction of the maji, in which this king was a principal actor. Herod. iii. 79. --- The Persians were ordered to keep the 13th of Adar, on account of the preservation of the royal family, and the ruin of a great enemy. C.

Ver. 23. All. Gr. "Salvation is to us, and to all well-affected Persians: but a memorial of destruction to all who are traitors to us."

Ver. 24. And. Gr. "But every country or city throughout the kingdom, which shall not comply, shall be consumed with the spear and fire in wrath." ---

Beasts. Gr. adds hyperbolically, "and birds, and also be accounted most abominable for ever." H. --- Similar expressions occur in the prophets, to denote an entire destruction. Jer. ix. 10. &c. Mardochai and Esther have left us in this work the most perfect example of virtue. The latter is given us a pattern of Christian sovereigns, and a figure of the Church. S. Jerom ad Paulin. (C.) and prol. in Sophon. --- Like Judith, she proved the salvation of her people, and the ruin of their adversaries. Nothing could be more striking, (W.) or visible, than the hand of God in these transactions. H. --- Esther was also a type of the blessed Virgin, by whose intercession the head of the serpent is crushed,

**and letters of grace succeed to the hand-writing that stood against us.
S. Thomas, prol. in ep. Cath. W.**